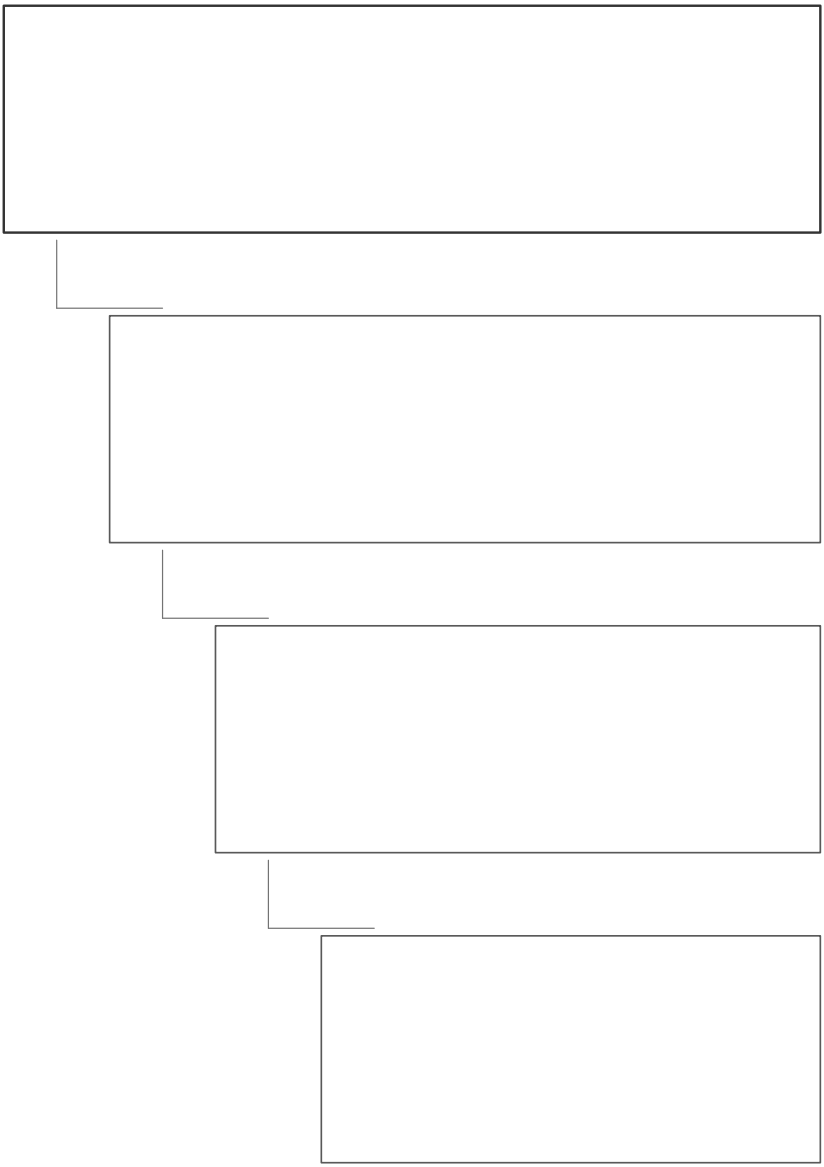Stepped hierarchy notes